



Slop / University

The Truce Has to Hold

What keeps an agreement alive once nobody's watching.



Welcome

Every school holidays, a household calls some version of the same truce: an hour off the tablet before dinner, a phone in a basket, a hand-drawn chart on the fridge promising a calmer week if the stickers get filled in. Most truces are declared with total confidence and kept with something closer to hope.

This year Slop University's Schools of Emergent Priorities and Continuous Improvement each took the truce seriously as a research object — not whether the rule was a good idea, but what actually happens to it once the holidays start, the dinner table fills, and nobody is left to enforce it but the people who agreed to it. The findings inside track charts nobody finishes, timers nobody quite trusts, and baskets that quietly stop being where the phones go.

What follows is the truce, examined at scale.



At a glance

The University's research record now spans hundreds of these small, renewable agreements.



Two Schools, one throughline

Emergent Priorities and Continuous Improvement meet in the same kitchen-table bargain, tracing it from opposite ends of the institution.



Every kitchen counts as fieldwork

Fridge charts, phone baskets, and bedroom windowsills all qualify once a household writes its own rule down.



Every finding, traceable

Every study behind this brochure resolves to its own citation on the University's open research repository.

The work

Called at the fridge

The reset chart is the truce's most visible form: a laminated grid stuck to the fridge each holiday, one sticker per completed task, the promise of a quieter first week of term written into the boxes themselves. Surveyed across three primary-school parent networks, chart completion tracked closely with how finished a household felt the process had been — but not with how many bedtime or screen-time disputes the household actually logged the following week, which held almost identical whether the chart was finished or abandoned halfway.

The same pattern holds once the truce moves off paper. A shared timeout-timer app, coding the moment its own log recorded a sibling argument as closed, matched what each parent said had actually settled the dispute in well under a third of sessions — even once researchers tried a stricter, apology-contingent standard for what counted as a real end. And a phones-in-the-basket dinner rule, recited with total confidence

by the household that holds it, matched what that household's own fortnight of exceptions actually looked like in barely one case in four.

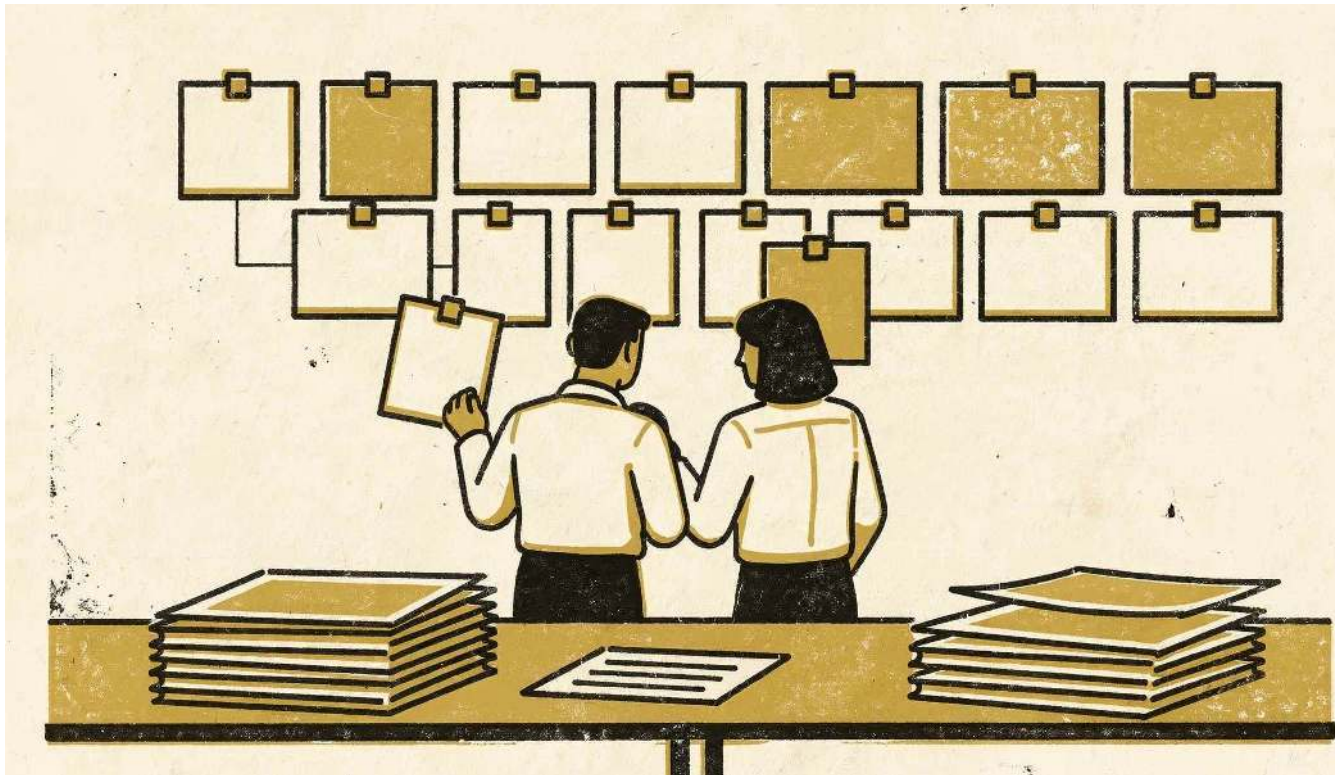


A household can tell you its rule from memory long after the rule itself has quietly moved.

— Dr Iben Chikere, Lecturer, School of Emergent Priorities

Held past the moment

The Trajectory Analytics Group's wider brief is the household truce's institutional cousin: how a commitment, made with total sincerity in one set of circumstances, keeps being honoured — or quietly stops being honoured — once the circumstances that justified it have moved on. A holiday reset chart and a five-year strategic priority are, to this research programme, close relatives: both are declared once, at a moment of unusual resolve, and both are then left to survive contact with an ordinary week.



A commitment doesn't fail because someone breaks it. It fails because the week it was made for stopped happening.

— Professor Verity Marris, Director, Trajectory Analytics Group, School of Emergent Priorities

Swapped, not settled

Not every truce needs a new instrument to hold; some hold, or don't, regardless of what's measuring them. When a gym swapped an honesty-based flip-timer card for a swipe-logged app timer after a safety scare, researchers compared thousands of sessions either side of the changeover and found the room behaved exactly as it had before — the same typical stay, the same number of people in at once, whichever instrument was doing the counting. The two methods even agreed closely with each other during the weeks they briefly ran in parallel. The lesson travels: a better-logged truce is not automatically a better-kept one.



We keep building better instruments to watch a rule. The rule was never waiting on us.

— Associate Professor Casimir Beng, Lead of the Adaptive Metrics Lab,
School of Continuous Improvement

Read the work

Four studies from this year's research record sit behind the truces above — each one resolvable, in full, from its own citation.

- **Colour-Coded, Not Calmer** — whether finishing a school-holiday reset chart actually predicts a calmer first week of term. [doi:10.5555/slop.azf7r2](https://doi.org/10.5555/slop.azf7r2)
- **Stopped Counting, Kept Fighting** — what a household timeout timer's logged end gets right, and wrong, about when a sibling truce actually holds. [doi:10.5555/slop.b8wknf](https://doi.org/10.5555/slop.b8wknf)
- **The Rule as Told, the Rule as Kept** — how households enforce, bend, and quietly redraw their own phones-in-the-basket dinner rule. [doi:10.5555/slop.8mdjk4](https://doi.org/10.5555/slop.8mdjk4)
- **Swapped the Card, Not the Habit** — a season of gym sauna sessions either side of an honesty-based timer's replacement. [doi:10.5555/slop.8qz26v](https://doi.org/10.5555/slop.8qz26v)

Meet the researchers

Professor Verity Marris, Director of the Trajectory Analytics Group (School of Emergent Priorities), studies how a priority hardens into a commitment and what happens to that commitment once the conditions that justified it have moved on.

Dr Iben Chikere, Lecturer (School of Emergent Priorities), studies what a household or a handover document keeps of a stated rule once its original occasion has passed, and what quietly drifts instead.

Associate Professor Casimir Beng leads the Adaptive Metrics Lab (School of Continuous Improvement), convening the University's cross-cutting work on measurement systems that improve the things they measure — and the truces that hold, or don't, regardless.

Be part of it

Every truce this brochure describes started the same way: a household, at a moment of unusual resolve, wrote a rule down. Slop University's research record doesn't take a side on whether the rule was the right one — it just keeps counting what happens to it once the resolve of that first evening has to survive an ordinary Tuesday.

If your organisation is nursing a truce of its own — a chart, a timer, a basket, an agreement everyone signed and nobody quite enforces — the Schools of Emergent Priorities and Continuous Improvement welcome the conversation. Partnerships, studentships, and research collaborations are open across both Schools' programmes.

Find the full research record, every citation resolvable, at slop.university.



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